

ANI

PROPITIATING KALI
West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee performs rituals during the inauguration of the light and sound show at the Dakshineswar temple near Kolkata, Jun. 2022

decade, as the BJP gained strength in Bengal through its muscular Hindutva, exemplified by loud Ramnavami processions, the TMC saw it best to counter it by plumping for Bengal's great liberal, secular and reformist tradition. Criticism of the BJP's brand of politics left it open to charges of being 'anti-Hindu' and prone to 'minority appeasement'. The 2019 parliamentary poll results served as a wake-up call when the BJP won 18 of West Bengal's 42 seats, becoming the principal opposition in the state. A CSDS Lokniti post-poll survey revealed that the TMC won just 32 per cent of the Hindu vote share compared to the BJP's 57 per cent. Alleged corruption of TMC leaders and charges of widespread violence during the 2018 panchayat polls certainly contributed, but it was clear that the BJP's tactic of religious polarisation had also worked. Since then, a course correction has followed. In 2019, promises were made to pay stipends to Hindu priests, and made good before the 2021 assembly polls. That year, too, appeals were made for the first time to Muslims to not slaughter cows in public, keeping in mind "others' sentiments".

BJP'S CHARGE OF 'MINORITY APPEASEMENT' DIDN'T BOTHER TMC TILL THE 2019 LS RESULT FORCED IT TO TAKE NOTE

The about-turn seemed to have paid off. In the 2021 assembly polls, the TMC's Hindu vote rose by seven percentage points at the cost of a proportional downslide in the BJP's voteshare. Even so, 50 per cent of the Hindus remained with the BJP; and the TMC managed 39 per cent of the majority community's votes. However, going by the bitter, no-holds-barred poll campaign, it was a great win for the TMC, and it took heart from the fact that it snatched back some Hindu votes from the BJP's clutches.

Now, with BJP's Leader of the Opposition Suvendu Adhikary strutting around with a saffron *tika* on his forehead and leaving no chance to taunt Mamata for alleged minority appeasement, the TMC is consciously wearing its Hindu credentials on its sleeves. And how they are cleaving to the new policy! When TMC MP Mahua Moitra made a passing remark on her personal belief of Goddess Kali